

THE WESTERN DAILY

THE WALTHAMSTOW MURDER.

Mrs Gouldstone, who is exerting herself to the utmost to save her unfortunate husband's life, writes to state her solemn belief that when the crime was committed, the convict was not responsible for his act. She says: "During our five years of married life I frequently noticed that my husband was absent-minded and given to brooding. If he were asked a question he would not, no matter how simple it was, or however easy to answer, reply at once. He would think over it, and sometimes say something not concerning the question.

We commenced housekeeping on 21s a week, and latterly we had 25s. It was sometimes difficult to make ends meet when the children came so rapidly, and this weighed on his mind, I fear, although he never spoke of it to me—except in the way of saying how sorry he was that my hands were so full, and that we could not go out together as we used to do. That was the only way in which he ever spoke of the burden of the family. Before we had the first child, and right on till the birth of the second, we regularly went to church. The second child was weakly, and the first was still only a baby, so that we could not leave the house together. For all his occasional absent ways he was very lively, and as I had all to do with the spending of the money, and did not let him know if there was any trouble about payments when there was a confinement or sickness in the house, I always found it very easy to turn his attention to something brighter. He was very kindly with me and the children, handy and willing if they were ailing, and he constantly helped me in household duties. He was a man who had few acquaintances except his own relatives and his fellow-workmen, and he was nearly always at home when not at work, except on the Sunday morning, when he occasionally took a walk alone. But for hours together he would keep the children going with his concertina, which he was very fond of playing, when I was engaged in household duties. The children were very fond of him and were never tired of listening to the concertina. If he seemed worried, amusing the children—at which he was very good—or a remark from me would at once change his mood. He was painfully aware of how easy it was for him to get worried, and he has often said to me that it was a good job he had not much to think of, as if he had he believed it would turn his brain. Nothing that ever he said or did before the loss of the little ones gave me the least fear that he would take his own life or that of any one else. But shortly before my last babes were born he said to me that he believed he had not many weeks to live, which was a strange remark that I have often thought of since. He never complained, except that he did not know how I should manage with my hands already so full, and soon to be even fuller. But then lots of people manage on less, and we did very well, and when I put this before him he ceased to be moody and absent. I never knew till very lately that there was any insanity in the family. . . . Since the occurrence I have seen my husband three times at the House of Detention, once at the Old Bailey and yesterday (Tuesday) in the prison at Chelmsford. On each occasion he has been as happy as a child at play. At Chelmsford he said he had seen several relatives whom he had not met for a long time, but neither he nor I made any reference to the fate of the children. His sister and aunt accompanied me yesterday. He asked me to take care of myself, and, turning to his relatives, said, 'You will take care of her, won't you?' Then he said, 'I have broken God's commandment, and I must expect to suffer, but He will forgive me for what I have done.' He realises his position in so far as he believes he will die, but he seems to have no notion of the enormity of killing the children. In a letter I had from him he spoke of them as being in heaven, where he hopes soon to join them. Here is a letter I have from him, dated the 15th, in the same strain:—

My Dear Wife—I feel it is a Pleasure to Write a few Lines to you and trusting to God that it will find you as well as Can Be Expected after the Dreadful news but I am thankful to God that I feel Happy as I may Expect and I Hope you will Look to God to Help you and He Will Comfort you as Well as myself Dearest Wife I Hope you will Receive this Letter this Evening and than I Hope you wont fret much about me as what God Doest is for the Best and I Hope You will Be able to Come and See Me Over a Shore Time and I Hope Aunt and all at Home are quite Well and all Cousins and Rember me to all that know me, and Let Cousin Gouldstone in Mash Street know How I am and I am going to send a few Lines to Mr G. Sampford and I Hope all Will forgive me for I am thinking about you all But I Hope you all Will Pray to God to Comfort One and all of you and Bear that in mind that God Will forgive all Dear Wife do not fret about what I Have to Live Upon Because I Can Have What I Wish for in my Living from the Prison and you may Believe that the Chapeling will Give me all I Require and I thank God that I Have been preparing for the Other World and which I shall do more so now and Live in Hopes to meet you all in Heaven. So Good By God Bless You

WILLIAM GOULDSTONE.
Her Majesty's Prison, Chelmsford, Essex,
September 15th, 1883.

I have no doubt he did not know and could not help what he did. He was always most affectionate to me and the children, and I cannot think that he should suffer a shameful death for what would be to him, if he only understood it, the most awful distress."